Transgender Name Change Guide

Davidson County

Disclaimer

The following guide assumes residency in Davidson County, Nashville TN.

It is also advised that you save your old identification documents even after receiving your new documents, as several steps in the process require providing both old and new identification.

Note that this guide should not be considered legal advice, and that it does not necessarily cover everything. This is simply an outline of how a trans person might go about their name and gender change, including information and processes that members of QUILT had to learn and do for their own transitions.

The State of Federal Changes

With the issuing of Executive Order 14168 declaring two immutable sexes, federal agencies have had to follow suit in denying trans people changes to gender on federally issued documents such as passports and social security records.

Trans people can **no longer** (as of January 2026):

- Get or renew visas with an updated gender marker.
- Pick a gender marker other than M or F on federal employee insurance (FEHB).
- Update their gender marker with the social security administration (this is strictly in their systems, and is not printed on the card anyway).
- Get passports with updated names but with changed gender markers.

However trans people **still can** (as of January 2026):

- Get passports with updated names but without changed gender markers.
- Get or renew visas with updated names but old/unchanged gender markers.
- Can change your gender with marketplace insurance.
- Update their name with the social security administration.

We will attempt to keep this guide up to date with the latest changes as they happen.

Getting Started

The Court Order

Timeline: 2 - 4 weeks
Fees: $159.50 (petition) + $11.00 per order copy

The name change court order is the first document you will need to start the process for your legal name change. You will submit a petition to the court for a name change, after a few weeks they will give you a court date, and then at your court date you will testify to the judge (extremely short process, ~5 minutes) about why you are seeking the name change as well as some other information. If you were not born in Tennessee, you can still change your name here but must meet the residency requirements linked below.

The hearing for the date includes a few simple questions that you testify to:

1. Whether or not you are a resident of Davidson County
2. Whether or not you have been convicted of a felony
3. The reason for changing your name
    a. Some people mention their transition, others say because the name fits them better, others mention preference
    b. As of this time there doesn't seem to be any bearing in how you present your desire for a name change, just that you wish to have one
    c. If you would rather not include transition related information you can state "preference" or "fits me better" in your petition and in your testimony at the hearing

The Name Change Petition and detailed instructions for Davidson county can be found in the Chancery Court's forms here: https://chanceryclerkandmaster.nashville.gov/forms/

Adult Name Change Requirements

Bring the following with you to the county clerk's office at 1 Public Square Suite 308, Nashville, Tennessee 37201:

1. A completed copy of the Name Change Petition form
2. Cash, a cashier's check, or a credit/debit card to cover the $159.50 fee (no personal checks)
3. A copy of your birth certificate
4. Photo identification (driver's license, passport, or other applicable photo ID)
5. Social Security card
6. Proof of residency (see here: https://www.tn.gov/safety/driver-services/classd/tnresidency.html)

Minor Name Changes

For minors changing their name, their legal guardian(s) must sign the name change petition as well as appear at the hearing with the minor.

The wording of the court's instructions says "*both parents / legal guardians*". The court states that name changes for minors *must* be approved by both "natural parents" and that a stepparent cannot approve such a change unless there is a court order of adoption or any other type of court order that terminates the rights of the "natural parent". If the parent has not had these rights terminated they may prevent the minor from changing their name.

If the minor's birth certificate does not identify the father, they must go through legitimation proceedings first before being able to submit the name change petition. These proceedings are to legally establish that the minor was born to both parents.

When you are ready to submit the petition, bring the following with you to the county clerk's office at 1 Public Square Suite 308, Nashville, Tennessee 37201:

1. A completed copy of the Name Change Petition
2. A copy of the child's birth certificate showing the names of both parents or an order of paternity / legitimation
3. Copies of the birth certificates of both parents / legal guardians
4. Photo identification such as a driver's license, passport, or comparable official photo identification of both parents / legal guardians and of the minor child, if available
5. If the parents / legal guardians are married, a copy of the marriage license or marriage certificate
6. Social Security card or naturalization document for both parents / legal guardians and for the minor child, if any
7. Proof of residency in Davidson County, ideally for both parents / guardians (see here: https://www.tn.gov/safety/driver-services/classd/tnresidency.html)

Restrictions To Name Changes

The following people cannot change their name (outside of marriage, divorce, or adoption) according to Tenn. Code Ann. § 29-8-101:

1. Those convicted of first or second degree murder
2. Those convicted of an offense requiring sexual offense registry
3. Those convicted of felonies
    a. The code mentions that felons submitting name changes are "presumed to be made in bad faith, to defraud or mislead, to cause injury to an individual or to compromise public safety."
    b. The petition can be granted given evidence that it is not made in an attempt to defraud of mislead, but if you are in this position you should consult a lawyer for legal counsel

Virtual Hearings

The court will sometimes issue you a virtual hearing, and as of December 2024 the court was using Jabber by Cisco. This software is outdated and was even given an end-of-life notice by Cisco.

The court's information on using Jabber is extremely lacking, and their instructions mention things that no longer exist or no longer work.

If you are assigned a virtual hearing, you will either need to ask for an in-person one or get ahold of either an iPhone or iPad. Android phones, Windows computers, and macOS computers all seemed to not work with Jabber, and using iOS was the only solution.

After Your Hearing

Congratulations, you have a new name!

When your name change is approved you can head back to the clerk's office to pick up copies of the order. Each copy is $11.00 (again paid for by cash, cashier's check, or credit/debit only) and they will be signed and stamped. It's recommended to get 3-5 copies, as you'll need to send off copies occasionally for other applications like passports or birth certificate changes. You should also keep a backup copy in a safe location, and additionally a copy in the glove box of your car would be good to have until you get your driver's license updated.

Housing

Timeline: 1 - 2 weeks
Fees: None

Because of how many other changes require residency proofs *with your new name* you should update your housing documents as soon as possible.

Renters

For renters, this will involve taking your court order to your landlord / leasing office so that they can file your new name and give you an updated lease agreement. You may have to re-sign the agreement for them.

If the person you speak with says they cannot update names on leases, ask to speak with a manager. They may not legally be required to give you a lease with an updated name, but speaking with the right person might get you what you need. If they refuse to update the lease you'll have to wait until the lease expires to update your name on it. An updated lease is not a specific requirement for proof of residency, but it is helpful.

You must also change the name on your renter's insurance and provide it to your landlord / leasing office ASAP. Speak with them to determine whether you need to do this prior to updating your lease, but it is likely that the order doesn't matter as long as they get it within a timely manner.

Public Housing, Section 8, & HCV

If you are living in public housing or through a Section 8 / Housing Choice Voucher program you will need to update your name on your application with the relevant agency. If your housing is through the Metropolitan Housing & Development Agency you can update using their RentCafe portal here. If your housing is through the Tennessee Housing Development Agency you can update using their RentCafe portal here.

Please contact the agencies if you have further questions. If you are receiving vouchers you will need to update your name with the private owner of the property as well (see above section).

Homeowners

To update the name on a deed you will need to have a copy of the current deed and sign your new name to a new deed in the presence of a public notary. You will then file this new deed at the county clerk's office.

The Register of Deeds Fee calculator can help you estimate the cost.

Utilities

Be sure to update your utilities as well (described later in this document) as often utility bills are the most convenient form of residency documentation you will have access to.

For Nashville Electric Service this can be done by reaching out to them via their contact form to start the process. The email for NES is custserv-genesys@nespower.com but it's unclear whether emailing this address directly will get a service ticket started for you. After someone reaches out to you they'll ask you to provide the legal name change order.

Sometimes apartments that include water/sewage in your bill will actually use a third party service like submeter.com to do the billing. In these situations you will also need to reach out to the 3rd party company to ensure your name gets updated in their system. Sometimes (as with submeter.com) this must be done *after* you change your name on your lease so that it your name doesn't get flipped back to your old name on utility bills by the apartment complex.

Note About NES Emails

For some reason NES's internal systems are a bit clunky and the name used to *address you* (e.g. "Hello, <your name>") in paperless billing may not be updated. After some email exchanges they reported that they cannot make changes to the online account only the "service system". Turn paper billing off and back on might work or just opting for paper bills as after they update your name in the "service system" it is correct on the bills themselves, just not ne in other places within the application or email communications.

Social Security

Timeline: 2 - 4 weeks
Fees: None

Note on Federal Guidelines

With the issuing of Executive Order 14168 you can no longer change your gender marker with the Social Security Administration. You may still change your name, which will be covered in the section below.

The gender marker recorded with the Social Security Administration is only part of their internal systems and is not reflected on your Social Security Card.

Changing Your Name

The Social Security Administration website offers services including changing your name.

You can also go to an in-person office to change your name, but will need to make an appointment as the offices no longer accept walk-ins. Information about scheduling appoints can be found by either calling your local office or making an appointment online.

Birth Certificate

Timeline: 2 - 4 weeks
Fees: $15 (filing fee) + $15.00 per order copy

Note On State Guidelines

In July of 2023 Tennessee governor Bill Lee signed Public Chapter 486 into law establishing "sex" as "a person's immutable biological sex as determined by anatomy and genetics existing at the time of birth and evidence of a person's biological sex."

The Tennessee Department of Health has stopped changing gender markers on birth certificates to accurately reflect gender changes for transgender people even though the text of the law does not include any enforcement provision, nor any penalty provisions for failure to comply with the law.

Changing Your Name

After obtaining your legal name change you can send a copy of the name change order with an application of amendment to the Tennessee Department of Health at:

> TN Vital Records
> 710 James Robertson Parkway
> 1st Floor Andrew Johnson Tower
> Nashville, TN 37243

They require a $15 filing fee and charge $15 per birth certificate copy. It's advised you purchase at least two copies of your birth certificate so that you can keep an extra copy on hand in case one gets lost, damaged, or is being used by another entity such as if you provide your birth certificate to the U.S. Department of State when obtaining a passport.

Passport

Timeline: 2 - 4 weeks or around 2 weeks if expedited shipping + 1-2 day shipping
Fees:

- $165 new passport
  - Or $130 if renewal
  - Or $100 if new passport or renewal for someone 16 or under
- $30 if getting passport card
  - Or $15 if new passport or renewal for someone 16 or under
- + $60 if using expedited processing
- + $22.05 if using 1-2 day shipping

Note on Federal Guidelines

The issuing of Executive Order 14168 made it so you can no longer change your gender marker with the US Department of State, however in June 2025 a U.S. District Court judge for the District of Massachusetts ruled that the department must continue providing gender marker changes as part of *Orr v. Trump*.

As of September 2025 the US Department of State's website stated that "certain individuals" seeking M, F, or X markers on passports may receive them. However, by November 2025 the supreme court granted a request to stay the preliminary injunction in Orr v. Trump, allowing the state department to discriminate and require sex at birth on passports.

You may still change your name, which will be covered in the section below.

Note on Passport Cards

Some states like Tennessee do not allow you to change your gender marker on state driver's licenses. This can make showing your driver's license an uncomfortable experience and potentially 'out' you.

Aside from passport books, the US Department of State also issues passport cards. These are the size of driver's licenses and can serve the following purposes:

- Proof of identity and citizenship
- Domestic air travel (it's REAL ID compliant!)
- Land and sea travel from Mexico, Canada, Bermuda, and some Caribbean countries.
- Proof of age at bars and venues (also compatible with most ID scanners)

The passport card does **not allow for international travel by air**.

Passport cards are cheaper than books, so if you do not need international travel or a second passport document you can opt for the card only!

Obtaining New Passports

Detailed instructions are here - new passports must be filed in person at a Passport Acceptance Facility.

You will need to submit form DS-11 at the facility with the following:

- Proof of citizenship (this will be your birth certificate)
- A photo ID (such as driver's license, government employee ID, green card, etc.)
- Payment method for the fees

These proofs of identification should be updated prior to getting your passport.

If you do not have these updated you will only be able to get a passport with your old name, and then change the name later via renewal.

Obtaining Renewal Passports

Detailed instructions are here.

Renewing your passport allows you to change your name and gender marker (if needed).

You **cannot** renew a passport that meets any of the following criteria:

- Issued before your 16th birthday
- Issued more than 15 years ago
- Is damaged, lost, or stolen
- **Issued in your previous name, and you do not have a legal document like a marriage license to prove your legal name change**

To renew you will fill out form DS-82 (can be mailed or done online instead of being in-person) and include the following:

- Passport photo
- Passport fee
- Your most recent passport (this will be mailed back separately from the new passport)
- Name change court order (an original copy, no photocopies!)

It can take a bit of time to get your new passport - using expedited processing and 1-2 day shipping can help. Be sure to save your old passport after it's mailed back to you.

Driver’s License & Automobile

Timeline: 2 - 4 weeks
Fees:

- $8 - $16 for updated license (based on duplication fee calculation)
- $14 for new car title

Note on State Guidelines

In July of 2023 Tennessee governor Bill Lee signed Public Chapter 486 into law establishing “sex” as “a person’s immutable biological sex as determined by anatomy and genetics existing at the time of birth and evidence of a person’s biological sex.”

The Tennessee Department of Safety has stopped changing gender markers on drivers’ licenses to accurately reflect gender changes for transgender people even though the text of the law does not include any enforcement provision, nor any penalty provisions for failure to comply with the law.

It is unclear what will happen if you apply for a new license with an updated gender marker (especially if you have all your other documentation updated such as birth certificate, passport, etc), and should be down at your own discretion.

Driver’s License

You will need to visit a Driver’s Services Center to update your license, more information can be found here.

Be sure to bring the following with you:

- Your old driver’s license
- An original copy of your name change order
- Any additional documents required if you’re applying for a Real ID for the first time

For Real ID, you will also need to explicitly make an appointment using the above link.

You will be charged a duplicate fee ranging from $8 to $16 dollars. The fee will depend on the number of duplicates you’ve had and the type of license you have. All Certificate for Driving, Temporary Driver License and Temporary ID duplicates cost $28.00.

Car Title

The car title is a simple process as long as you have your name change order and the original car title. You can take these documents, along with one or more forms of photo ID, to the Davidson County Clerk and request a new title with your new name. The fee for a replacement title is $14.00.

Insurance

Your car insurance will be able to be changed only after you have updated and received your new driver's license. You can update your car insurance online for most insurance providers, but be sure to check with your provider on the exact steps.

Because Tennessee does not allow for gender marker changes on licenses, you may run into trouble changing your gender marker with your insurance. It's best to contact your insurance and ask whether they have an exception for the situation.

Financial Institutions

Timeline: 1 - 2 weeks for each change or new card
Fees: None

Banks, 401k, HSA, etc.

Your bank should be able to update your name easily as long as you bring the following documents:

1. A certified copy of your name change order
2. An identifying document (photo ID, birth certificate, etc)

Be sure to put in orders for new debit (and credit, if yours are through your bank) card(s) while you're there. Double check with them that the name is being updated on the new cards and that it's spelled correctly.

If your bank has no physical locations (e.g. Ally Bank) you can search their site for "name change request". They will typically publish the form needed to change your name with them, and the form will have instructions on what is needed, how to submit it, etc.

You will need to do the same for other accounts like if you have an HSA, 401k, or other financial accounts. The process will typically be the same for all of them - filing a form with your name change order and supporting documents required by the institution's form.

Credit Bureaus

You must get one or more forms of updated identification (SSA card, passport, driver's license, etc.) as well as updated proof of residency (driver's license, lease agreement, deed, pay stub, utility bill, etc.) before doing this step! Otherwise the credit bureaus will kick your applications back to you with errors.

This step should be done fairly early on as to not cause issues running credit reports if you need to do things like take out a loan, apply for a credit card, etc.

There are three main bureaus you will need to update with:

- Equifax
  - Can be filed online, but you have to make an account on their site
- Experian
  - Can be filed online, but you have to make an account on their site
- Trans Union
  - Can be filed by mail, they have a guide for it here

The process involves sending the bureaus a copy of your name change order as well as proof of identification and proof of residency.

Note that for Equifax and Experian changing your name on your *credit report* does not actually change the name for the online accounts. If you signed up with your old name, you will have to call their customer support to actually change it on the account. Leaving it as your old name does not effect your actual credit report.

After you update your name with the bureaus, they will typically send you a copy of your credit report which you can use to verify that your name was correctly updated.

Airlines

Timeline: 1 week max, but usually immediate
Fees: None

Each airline stores your information separately when you book from them, so even if you have gotten a new license, passport, etc. you will still need to update your information with each airline you fly with.

When traveling by air, your identification *must* match the name and gender that you used to book the reservation. If you have only done the legal name change but have no updated documents, you would also have to book a flight reservation using your old name and gender.

With most airlines this can be done online via their online account management. Some airlines, like Southwest, require you to call to make the gender marker change (meaning its two change requests total).

To make these changes you will usually need to provide:

- A copy of your **old identification** (driver's license, passport, etc)
- A copy of your **new identification** (driver's license, passport, etc)
- Legal name change court order

Some airlines can also update existing reservations when you request a name change, but be sure to check with the airline. You will likely not be able to get through the airport and board your flight if your reservation and identification don't match!

Health Insurance

Timeline: 2-4 weeks to make change and receive new insurance cards
Fees: None

Note on Federal Guidelines

While the issuing of Executive Order 14168 does codify "immutable sex", it doesn't appear to apply to marketplace insurance on healthcare.gov. These insurance plans are maintained by private companies who have their own guidelines and will (more likely than not) let you update your gender/sex with them.

Healthcare.gov

If your insurance is through Healthcare.gov you will need to update your name and gender/sex marker through the main website. This is done by logging in and under "Your Applications" selecting the application for your current health insurance.

From here you will select "Report A Life Change" and essentially complete the same application that you previously filed, but with new information for your name and gender/sex (if applicable).

The process is a bit confusing but essentially you're updating the application that you already filed with new information. **Be sure to not change the insurance plan as part of this application update.** After you have completed the application Healthcare.gov will take your new information and submit it to your private insurance company for you as a life change event. You can verify with your private insurance later that the changes were successful, but you should not have to contact them directly to make these changes for marketplace insurance plans.

Note On Healthcare.gov Account Name

While the name on your *insurance* is part of your insurance application, the actual Healthcare.gov account that you log in with stores its own copy of your name. **This name is not updated when you update your insurance application / report a life change.** In my experience speaking with customer support is also extremely unhelpful, as they seem to only be trained on name changes through your *insurance application* and don't know that the account name is different.

If you are registering for marketplace insurance for the first time, it's advised to get your name change documents in order first and just register with your new name for the account. You can register this account before actually submitting insurance applications, though they do verify the same via the Social Security Administration so you will likely need to change your name with them first.

Medicare / TennCare

For Medicare, changing your name with the Social Security Administration satisfies the name change process.

For TennCare, you must fill out this form and send it to their office via mail or e-mail. The addresses are listed in the form. For “proof as to why your information needs to change” you should include a copy of your legal name change as well as copies of identification you have with your new name (old name identification can be included as well to prove your old and new name).

Workplace Insurance

Updating insurance through your workplace is very simple, as you’ll just need to contact your employer or the HR department for the company and give them your new information. They will be able to update your information on the company’s insurance plan from there.

Be sure to have updated your information with the Social Security Administration by this time. You should also be able to update your gender on your insurance at this time.

Apple Accounts

Timeline: 1-2 days
Fees: None

If you use macOS, iOS, iPadOS, etc. you will have an Apple Account and likely an iCloud email address. There are a few caveats to updating your Apple Account / iCloud Mail that will be listed below.

Note that Apple ID has been renamed to Apple Account.

Changing Your Apple Account Addresses

Apple provides instructions for updating your primary address here, however there are a few caveats:

- You can create alias email addresses within iCloud Mail, but these aliases cannot be used as the primary address for your Apple Account (or for iCloud Mail).
- Once you update your primary address to a new address, the old/original account address will be marked with "This is an alias of your Apple Account primary email address" and you will not be allowed to remove that address.

You can use the following options for your new primary address:

- A secondary email service such as Gmail, Microsoft, Yahoo, etc.
- If subscribing to iCloud+, you can use a custom domain you own for your new primary address, which will also enable you to receive iCloud Mail using that custom address.

Updating Your iCloud Mail

Apple allows creating email aliases on iCloud Mail's web interface, see here for more information. You can use this to create a new iCloud address that you can be reached at.

Note that you are only allowed 3 aliases, and if you delete one its address cannot be used again. When you have 3 aliases and delete one, you must wait 7 days before creating another alias (see here).

Disabling Your Old Address

Apple support confirmed to us in a phone call January 2026 that the original email address you created your Apple Account / iCloud Mail with cannot be deleted from either service. However, you can take the following steps to ensure that the address is not usable:

1. In iCloud Mail *web version* go to Settings > Send From and disable the account.
2. In Messages go to Settings > iMessage, then disable the account under the section titled "You can be reached for messages at".
3. In FaceTime go to Settings > General, then disable the account under the section titled "You can be reached for FaceTime at".

This will ensure your old address is not reachable through Messages/FaceTime/Mail, however the old address will still be visible in the following places:

- The addresses list in Apple Account's "Sign-In & Security" settings on account.apple.com
- The addresses list in Apple Account's "Sign-In & Security" settings on macOS, iOS, iPadOS
- Messages and FaceTime settings (it will be present, but not enabled)
- iCloud Mail *web version* settings
  - Account > Primary Address (cannot be changed)
  - Account > Send From (will be present, but not enabled)

Also be sure to remove the address from your "Me" card in Contacts.

Google Accounts

As of January 2026 Google is still in the process of rolling out the ability to change your email address for your account, see here for details.

Self Employed / Business Owners

Timeline:

1 - 2 weeks for registered agent or business license change

Fees:

- $30 for a new Urban Service District business license
  - or $15 for a new General Service District business license
- $20 if needing to change registered agent

The following pertains to individuals who have an LLC for self employment or small business purposes. If you have any questions or concerns, you can call the TN Secretary of State's office (for business registration questions) or the Davidson County Clerk (for business license questions).

The state of TN does not keep record of the business owner name in their files, just the information about the LLC.

However, if you have declared yourself (rather than the LLC or your lawyer) as the registered agent, you will need to file a change in registered agent. The form for that can be found here, and the cost is $20:
https://sos.tn.gov/businesses/forms-and-fees

For tax filing you can log into your TNTAP account, select "Manage My Profile" (on the right, under the user greeting), and then freely update your name without having to submit documentation.

When submitting your annual reports with the Secretary of State, you can simply start using your new name. This also is self-report and requires no documentation to change.

Your Davidson County business license *does* actually record the owner name, but it's best to just update this when you're renewing your business license since you will have to pay the fee. It's recommended to do this in person at the Howard Office Building (700 President Ronald Reagan Way Suite 101, Nashville, TN 37210) so you can present your name change order and old business license to ensure your new one is ordered with your updated name.

Voter Registration

Timeline: 2-4 weeks
Fees: None

You can update your voter registration either online or by completing a mail-in form - more information is located here. Your name change request must be signed and received by the office no later than five days before an election in order to process the change.

You can **only** do this step after updating your driver's license.